

Quantum Healthcare: Imaging at the Edge of Possibility

4 of 5: Thoughts on Quantum Technology Based on Interpretations at SEEQA – A Conference Hosted at Oxford University.



TANYA MATANDA
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Merton College Chapel (Poster Sessions). Thoughts on Quantum Technology Based on Interpretations at SEEQA – A Quantum Conference Hosted at University.

Healthcare often advances in leaps. The X-ray cracked open the hidden world of bones. MRI made soft tissues visible. PET scans revealed metabolic processes. Each shift wasn't just technical—it changed how we think about disease, diagnosis, and ourselves.

Quantum sensing may be the next leap. Unlike today's millimetre-scale imaging, quantum devices like nitrogen-vacancy (NV) diamond magnetometers can pick up signals at the molecular or even atomic level. Imagine MRI scans that don't just show a tumour mass but reveal, in real

how individual cells respond to a drug. Or sensors that catch the early misfolding of proteins long before Alzheimer's symptoms appear.

Prototypes already exist. Teams in Munich have layered engineered dyes onto microfluidic chips, capturing water diffusion at the single-cell scale. Hospitals in Denmark are trialling atomic vapour sensors to catch subtle errors in MRI scans. Projects like Europe's PROMISE consortium are scaling NV-based sensors toward clinical readiness. What makes these devices disruptive is their practicality: many run at room temperature, without cryogenics that make quantum physics feel distant from everyday medicine.

Providers on the Frontline

- **Hospitals and Research Centers** will be the first movers. With capital and clinical capacity, they can integrate prototypes into oncology, neurology, and cardiology workflows. But retraining staff and managing liability will require deliberate governance.
- **Family Doctors and Primary Care** providers won't own the machines, but they'll receive quantum-informed diagnostics as part of lab reports. The challenge will be integration into everyday decision-making, without losing sight of compassion and patient-centred care.
- **Specialized Practices** stand to benefit most immediately—oncologists mapping tumour microenvironments, neurologists detecting protein aggregates. Yet they'll face ethical dilemmas: when is a molecular irregularity actionable, and when does it risk overdiagnosis?

The Health Informatics Angle

Quantum diagnostics aren't just about sharper pictures—they're about *kinds of data*.

- **Data volume:** Molecular-scale scans will generate terabytes per patient, demanding new infrastructure.
- **Integration:** Today's electronic health records already strain under genomics. Quantum-level data will force new standards to make it interoperable across hospitals, labs, and clinics.
- **Decision support:** Raw quantum signals need AI interpretation. Informatics becomes the bridge, but governance must define when outputs are “clinically actionable.”
- **Privacy and ethics:** A quantum health profile may reveal predispositions decades before symptoms—reviving old debates about confidentiality, autonomy, and justice.
- **Equity in datasets:** If only elite hospitals gather quantum data, AI results will skew. Informatics governance must plan for representative access.

Current Limitations

For all its promise, quantum healthcare remains at the prototype stage: devices are confined to research labs, requiring painstaking calibration in controlled environments. NV-diamond sensors and atomic vapour systems are still expensive and fragile, with data outputs that overwhelm today's electronic health records. Regulatory pathways are untested, and there is no consensus on how to classify or validate quantum-derived diagnostics. Clinically, the risk of overdiagnosis looms large: revealing molecular irregularities without clear therapeutic pathways could burden both patients and healthcare systems.

and physicians. In short, the science is running ahead of the infrastructure and without deliberate governance, early deployments could widen inequities rather than close them.

Governance Challenges

Quantum healthcare is as much a governance frontier as it is a scientific one.

- **Regulatory pathways:** Agencies need new categories for quantum diagnostics, beyond the scope of current device or assay frameworks.
- **Ethics and equity:** Boards must anticipate how molecular data affects privacy, insurance, and distributive justice.
- **Workforce readiness:** Radiologists, neurologists, and oncologists need training to handle overwhelming new datasets.
- **Partnership orchestration:** Universities, hospitals, and startups must be governed in consortia, not silos.

Where's the Investment Alpha?

The alpha isn't in chasing a single "quantum MRI startup." It lies in the adjacent spaces:

- **Materials and hardware:** Producers of engineered diamond chips and magnetometer systems.
- **Informatics infrastructure:** Companies enabling secure, interoperable storage and analysis of quantum-scale medical data.
- **AI middleware:** Algorithms and platforms that translate quantum signals into usable diagnostics.

- **Platform hospitals:** Early adopters that brand themselves as hubs for quantum-ready medicine.
- **Policy tailwinds:** Governments will likely subsidize quantum diagnostics for high-burden diseases like cancer and Alzheimer's—investors will anticipate this will move ahead of the curve.

Broader Impact Beyond Investment

Quantum healthcare is not only about markets—it's about reshaping the experience of medicine. For patients, earlier and more precise diagnoses could mean years gained in quality of life, not just length of life. For families, it could reduce the uncertainty that shadows chronic disease, replacing it with clearer pathways and earlier interventions. For clinicians, quantum-enabled diagnostics may restore confidence in decision-making, while also testing the profession's commitment to compassion and candour. And for health systems, the challenge will be to balance the promise of molecular-level insights with fairness, accessibility, and the enduring ethos that medical care should be rooted not just in data, but in human dignity.

The Takeaway

The second quantum revolution may arrive not in physics labs but in clinics. Hospitals will experiment, specialists will interpret, family doctors will translate, and patients will benefit—but only if governance and informatics keep pace.

For boards, this means stress-testing regulation, training, and equity frameworks. For investors, it means recognizing that the biggest return

come not from the scanner itself but from the **health informatics ecos** that govern, clean, and translate quantum data into usable care.

Quantum medicine is not just a breakthrough in imaging—it's a govern and informatics market. Those who understand both dimensions will be positioned to capture its value.

Research and writing supported by AI Systems.

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